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Into the Direwood

Large A Tier IIIIV Survival Horror Saga

Large A Fate's Edge Adventure Module

Version 0.9 →day

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*...where the forest never lets go and the roots drink only memory.
An ancient spear pierces a dead druid to a fortress of bone.
Pull it free, and the forest remembers how to scream.*

Contents

1	Into the Direwood (Tier IIIIV Adventure)	5
1.1	Setup and Hooks	5
1.2	Historical Truth	5
1.3	Adventure Structure	5
1.4	Name Quest Subsystem: Remembering the Forgotten	11
1.5	Key Threats	15
1.6	Environmental Horror	15
1.7	Rewards and Consequences	15
1.8	Using With Any Setting	15
1.9	Patron: The Heroine of the Mist	19
1.10	Nemesis Profile: The Heroine Shade	20
1.11	Artifact: The Golden Thorn	21
A	Preparation Checklist	22
A.1	Session Zero Considerations	22
A.2	PreSession Preparation	22
B	Pacing and Flow Management	22
B.1	Act I: Payden's Port	22
B.2	Act II: Through the Direwood	23
B.3	Act III: The Fortress Heart	23
C	Key Mechanical Reminders	23
C.1	Story Beat Economy	23
C.2	Environmental Horror Tags	23
D	Character Archetype Support	23
D.1	Tank/Controller Players	23
D.2	Striker/DPS Players	23
D.3	Support/Buffer Players	24
D.4	Utility/Scout Players	24
E	Thematic Reinforcement	24
E.1	Consistency Tips	24
E.2	Horror Pacing	24
F	Troubleshooting Common Issues	24
F.1	Players Moving Too Slowly	24
F.2	Players Rushing Ahead	24
F.3	Combat Dominance	24
F.4	Investigation Stalling	24
G	Optional Variations	25
G.1	Shortened Campaign	25
G.2	Increased Horror Focus	25
G.3	Mythic Heroism Focus	25

H Tracking Sheets and Handouts	25
H.1 Player Tracking	25
H.2 GM Tracking	25
I Conclusion	25
J Aeler Military Engineer	25
K Mistland Local Guide	26
L Zakov Smuggler Captain	26
M Linnic TraderRaider	27
N Lethaial Valewood Ranger	27
O Aelinnel Gnome Artificer	27
P Aelaerem Halfling Herbalist	28

1 Into the Direwood (Tier IIIIV Adventure)

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Premise and Tone

tem **Recommended Tier:** IIIIV (experienced crews) tem **Atmosphere:** Half cosmic horror, half survival horror tem **Themes:** Lost names, corrupted guardianship, identity erased by history, truth vs. myth

The Direwood is a blighted frontier forest where an ancient fortress vomits mist and undead into the world. Long ago, a nameless champion impaled a corrupted druid with a **gilden spear** but the act unleashed the Mist that devoured her, erased her name, and warped her soul into a tragic antagonist.

Deep within the Direwood lies the fortress heart where she and the druid remain bound in a cycle of torment. Heroes must enter, survive, and uncover the truth: **The curse persists not because the druid lives, but because the heroine's name was erased.**

Only by revealing her name and restoring her saga can the curse be broken.

1.1 Setup and Hooks

This adventure is **settingagnostic**. Any region bordering cursed wilderness can use it.

section*Universal Hooks

tem **The Mist Thickens:** Something wakes in the Direwood. Fog breaches warding lines new horrors stalk settlements. tem **A Fragment of Saga:** Scholars, oracles, or ravings speak of a "nameless champion" and a spear of gilded dawn. tem **Faith or Faction Interest:** Reformers, pilgrims, war cults, or occult orders want the fortress breached or sanctified. tem **A Bargain:** A ghostly figure visits a character in a dream: *"Find my name, free me... or drown with me."*

You may replace factions with whatever religions, orders, or political blocs exist in your campaign.

1.2 Historical Truth

Once, a powerful druid served as the Direwood's warden. When an exiled necromancer befriended him, their work twisted root and bone into deathmagic. The druid raised undead armies Shades, Mistwraiths, Shadewalkers, and beastthings.

A champion her culture forgot defeated him using a **gilden spear** of unknown origin.

But victory was a lie.

tem The druid's death ruptured a dimensional wound. tem Mist poured out, consuming the heroine and her companions. tem She became a bound shade hero and warden both now twisted into a **Guardian of Silence**.

The world remembered the druid as the villain but *forgot her name*. That erasure is the core of the curse.

1.3 Adventure Structure

Run this as a 35 act ordeal:

section*Act I: Payden's Port and the Forgotten Chord

Tone: political gothic + creeping horror

Premise: The warding bellline falters. Bells toll out of sequence, Mist incursions grow bolder, and refugees whisper of shapes in fog.

The PCs arrive in Payden's Port a seagarrison city of cracked statues, stormbeaten docks, and chanting wardens and are pulled into crisis.

The Hook: Only one thing can repair the failing bellline **the Chord of the First Curse:** a strip of woven gold and root, a relic that was *torn away and lost in the Direwood when the first curse was sealed*.

Legends say it once bridged sound and spirit, harmonizing the ward with the heroine's true name.

Act Beats

tem **Factional pressure:** The Aeler garrison, Mistlander priests, and Guild factors all demand different outcomes; each tries to recruit or manipulate the PCs. tem **Living omens:** Dead gulls arrange themselves in votive circles, fogchildren whisper names not spoken. tem **The first breach:** The city's outer bellline sputters; Mistwraiths claw at the docks. PCs must assist the wardens or improvise defenses gaining first taste of the Mist. tem **Call to action:** Divination, confession, or coercion leads to one truth: *the Chord lies deep in the Direwood, near the fortress where the heroine fell*. tem **The Charge:** "Retrieve the Chord and restore the bellline or the Port will drown in white." The PCs are sent through the breached ward with blessings, suspicions, or threats at their back.

Dread Timer Mark ticks when:

tem the party ignores port omens or visions tem they mishandle the dead or desecrate wards
tem they underestimate or bargain with Mist

If filled early, Act II becomes harsher and the heroine initially appears as a hostile nemesis.

Act I Exit Conditions:

tem the party crosses into the Direwood, tem an alliance (or enmity) with at least one faction is set, tem the first imprint of the nameless heroine haunts one PC.

section*Act II: Through the Direwood

Tone: Survival horror, mythic feverdream, predatory landscape.

Crossing the treeline is not entering a forest it is passing into a place shaped by memory, undeath, and betrayal. The Direwood resists mapping; it *reacts* to intrusion.

Environmental Themes

tem **Twisting Trails:** Paths repeat; distances elongate. A day's march may loop back to a familiar tree, now adorned with new corpses. tem **Living Landmarks:** Hollow oaks bleed pale sap, stone cairns whisper warnings, ravens speak in halfremembered curses. tem **Memory Echoes:** Scenes replay villagers fleeing, army banners burning, lovers separated yet the faces

blur and distort. tem **Dream Fatigue:** Rest is possible, but sleep is disturbed. PCs wake with soil under their nails, leaves in their hair, or frost upon their cheeks.

Adversaries and Threats

tem[Mistwraith Packs:] *Tier III* predators that sense rising fatigue; they do not eat *they erase*. PCs marked by fear or exhaustion attract them. tem[Shadewalkers:] *Tier IIIII* revenant infantry stonecold tacticians reenacting endless patrols until interrupted. tem[Hunger Wolves:] *Tier III beastspirits*, sinew stretched over bone, jaws unhinging to swallow light itself. tem[The Forgotten Chorus:] *Tier IV psychic hazard* mourning voices that harmonize grief into psychic drowning. tem[The Heroine's Phantom:] A *shifting Tier IV entity* sometimes guide, sometimes executioner. Her mood tracks the party's reverence for lost history.

Nightly Visitations Each night, one PC dreams of the nameless heroine:

tem Meeting her mother beneath a moonlit birch. tem Riding with oathsworn shieldsisters. tem Walking toward fire knowing she will die.

GM Note: Fragments arrive out of order, wrong names inserted only when her true name is spoken do the visions align.

Direwood Survival Procedures

tem At each travel segment, roll the **Direwood Consequence Table**. tem Reduce safe camp options firelight attracts attention, cold invites wraiths. tem Food spoils overnight unless blessed or sealed.

Direwood Encounter Generator

Roll once when entering a new sector or when the party loses direction.

Step 1: Terrain Distortion (d6)

tem Fog walls movement halved, perception impaired. tem Reverse stream water flows upward, whispers of drowned souls. tem Forest of empty armor hollow suits clatter as wind passes. tem Birch grove trees lean inward as if listening. tem Corpse orchard fruit grows from ribcages (*dangerous temptation*). tem Silent clearing sound dies, even thoughts echo.

Step 2: Threat Manifestation (d6)

tem Mistwraith Pack hunting fear scent. tem Shadewalker patrol marching in silent formation. tem Hunger Wolves circling camp perimeter. tem Memory echo forcing PCs into historical reenactments. tem Voice of the Heroine offering cryptic aid (or condemnation). tem *No creature* but the woods rearrange behind them.

Step 3: Psychological Pressure (d6)

tem One PC hears their name whispered from a corpse. tem A random PC dreams while awake vision interrupts action. tem Someone's equipment rots or tarnishes instantly. tem PCs

lose track of timenight becomes day without transition. tem PCs forget a small factnames, directions, purpose. tem PCs find something belonging to thembut aged or broken.

Step 4: Strange Reward or Revelation (optional d6)

tem A black feather giving +1d to bravery tests. tem A shard of gilt metal humming near the heart of the forest. tem A whisper of her true namewrong syllables, but directionally useful. tem A bone talisman*Ignore fear once, then crack under stress.* tem A halfremembered lullaby that soothes undead spirits. tem A map that leads in circles unless the party honors the dead.

GM Guidance: Use 12 results per segment. Combine for escalating horror.

Escalation Triggers Increase threat when:

tem PCs desecrate corpses or mock legends. tem Someone tries to rationalize the supernatural. tem A vision is ignored or laughed off.

At high escalation, the Heroine's Phantom appearsnot as ally, but as judge.

Role of the Heroine in Act II She is not a questgivershe is *the wound*. PCs must:

tem earn her attention through reverence or boldness, tem learn fragments of her forgotten name, tem survive her tests.

Only by **speaking her true name** does her attitude shift from hunter to guide.

The Name That Was Forgotten

The Direwood will not allow the heroine's name to be spoken lightly. Her identity shattered when she died unremembered; the party must **gather fragments** through visions, echoes, relics, and mercy.

Each revelation provides one **Name Fragment**. When all are gathered and spoken with intention, her wrath becomes sorrowand the way forward opens.

rule d8	Fragment Source	What the PCs Receive
rule 1	Whisper in dream	A syllable spoken by a weeping voice
2	Relic unearthed	Runesymbol etched in gilt metal
3	Mercy to dead	A spirit forms a phoneme in frost or ash
4	Heroine's phantom	She screams it in rage, misheard or inverted
5	Shadewalker patrol	Captain repeats her battlecry fragment
6	Shrine remnant	A carved votive holding half her namingmark
7	Mistwraith hunt	One wraith mimics her dying breathsound
8	The wood itself	Wind across hollow birches shapes the final tone
tomrule		

Guidance

tem **Fragments are ambiguous:** each is a syllable, rune, or phonetic gesture. tem Players must *interpret* wrong assembly draws her fury. tem If spoken prematurely, increase the **Dread Timer** by +1 and attract a spectral assault. tem Once all are gathered, speaking the true name pacifies her and reshapes Act IV.

Optional Twist The final fragment cannot be heard only *remembered*. A PC must sacrifice a cherished memory to speak it aloud.

section*Act III: The Fortress Heart

The fortress is not built it is *grown*. Petrified roots coil into walls, bonecolumns hold roofs of fungus stone, and halls pulse faintly as if remembering breath.

Tone: grim revelation + predatory architecture.

tem **Shades** recite campaigns that never resolved. tem The **druid's corpse** still hangs impaled by the golden spear, a font of eternal fog. tem The **nameless heroine** prowls silently testing, haunting, or confronting.

If the *Dread Timer* is high, she manifests as a lethal nemesis. If the PCs earned reverence or curiosity, she delivers riddles, cryptic lore, or halftruth bargains.

Threats of the Fortress

tem **Mistwraith Sentinels:** absorb Fatigue; attack as whispers that drain resolve. tem **Bone Choir Shades:** animate when disturbed, chanting fragments of battle oaths. tem **Shadewalker Wardens:** undead knights commanded by instinct only bodyguards without a master. tem **Grasping Roots:** attempt to root intruders in place; test Body + Athletics to break free. tem **Reflected Self:** mirrors show PCs as future undead risk Mental Strain on failed Resolve.

Fortress Traps and Wards Magical Traps

tem **BoneSigil Wards:** trigger phantom spear volleys. tem **Echo Brands:** mark targets nearby undead treat branded PCs as hated traitors. tem **Mist Spore Bursts:** cause hallucinations and misplaced action declarations. tem **Remembrance Locks:** doors open only when spoken with a name fragment.

Mundane Traps

tem Rootpit collapse leading to a crypt nursery of Shadewalkers. tem Impaling stakes grown from bone growths under leaf cover. tem Hollow floors that drop PCs into memoryecho chambers. tem Glyphetched bells that summon a Shade patrol if rung.

Room Generator: The Dire Stronghold Roll d10 for each chamber or turn deeper:

rule **d10 Room / Encounter**

- rule 1 Hall of Hollow Shields spectral infantry drill endlessly
 - 2 Bone Spindle Stair roots twist upward; false steps activate impaling branches
 - 3 The Echo Choir Shades lament their failed charge; listening risks Fatigue
 - 4 The Memory Pit visions drag one PC into a relived massacre
 - 5 Oath Archive bone tablets with names scored out; fragments hidden here
 - 6 The Bloodless Barracks Shadewalker knights frozen until disturbed
 - 7 Grove of Still Hearts petrified Druid seeds containing wraith embryos
 - 8 Hall of the Betrayed mirrors show the PCs as corrupted avatars
 - 9 RootChamber Gate door opens only to a true fragment spoken aloud
 - 10 The Spear Hall the druid's husk nailed to reality; the heroine watches
- tomrule

Adversary Table: Fortress Foes

rule **d6 Adversary**

- rule 1 Shade Cohort (35 spectral infantry, DV 3 vs Resolve)
 - 2 Mistwraith Pack (absorbs Fatigue before Harm)
 - 3 Shadewalker Knight (Cap 3 undead bodyguard wielding rusted rites)
 - 4 Echo Sorcerer (fragment of the druid, casts DV 4 control spells)
 - 5 The Forgotten Squire (undead child bearing a name rune fragment)
 - 6 Her ShrineGuardian Self a phantom of the heroine in life
- tomrule

Environmental Effects (1d6 per room)

tem **1: Breath Leech** PCs lose 1 Fatigue entering. tem **2: Time Loop** first action each turn repeats. tem **3: Whispering Winds** disadvantage on stealth. tem **4: Grief Pulse** one PC makes a sorrow check. tem **5: Bone Bloom** undead roots sprout midcombat. tem **6: Heroine's Watch** her phantom judges the action; aid or hinder.

GM Guidance: The Heroine as Dynamic Antagonist She is not merely a boss she is a *mirror*.

tem When PCs show **oathkeeping**, she grants a name fragment. tem When they show **hubris or desecration**, treat her as a deadly hunter. tem If her name is assembled, the fortress reorganises rootwalls peel back, the mist recoils, and the druid's corpse becomes vulnerable.

This act should end with a revelation, not a combat unless the party refuses to remember.

1.4 Name Quest Subsystem: Remembering the Forgotten

labelsubsec:name_questdexNameQuests

Premise Some truths cannot be killed only forgotten. The Heroine of the Mist can only be freed by remembering her.

section*Memory Track A shared party track with 6 boxes.

Mark one when:

tem uncovering a name fragment or true deed, tem fulfilling an oath tied to her story, tem suffering hardship to defend the innocent, tem being recognized by shades as her lost companions.

Effects at Thresholds

tem[2 Marks:] Shades hesitate; mist retreats briefly. tem[4 Marks:] The Heroine shifts from Nemesis to Trial. tem[6 Marks:] PCs may speak the Name final resolution triggers.

section*Name Fragments Fragments may be discovered, traded, stolen, or revealed through:

tem prophetic dreams, tem battlefield memories, tem ghostsongs, tem the Golden Thorn's revelations.

Each Name Fragment must be **correctly placed** in her saga requiring Roleplay + Lore + Presence.

section*Final Rite: Restoration of Name When all fragments fit:

tem[Her Shade kneels,] ceasing hostility. tem[The Mist lashes,] then withdraws. tem[The Heroine ascends,] becoming patron or guide.

The party must swear: *her saga shall be sung, her deeds recorded, her name remembered.*

Breaking this oath:

tem summons her wrath, tem marks all PCs as **oathbreakers**, tem the Mist becomes a nemesis for the rest of the campaign.

section*Act IV: Descent into the RootVault

Tone: metaphysical pursuit + sacrificial myth

Premise The RootVault is an inverted underworld where:

tem roots are ossified memory, tem words become walls, tem and oaths have gravity.

Here, sealed at the breachpoint of the First Curse, rests the **Resonant Keystone** a crystalline bellcore wrapped in the heroine's erasure.

Why It Matters Without it, the bellline can never be repaired the Mist spreads until shore cities fall.

With it, PCs can:

tem retune the warding line, tem awaken the quiet bells, tem and name the heroine back into existence.

Vault Threats

tem **NameEaters** spectral archivists that rip identity pages from memory. tem **Mist Stalkers** ragged emanations of the druid's will, trying to seize the Keystone to unbind the curse. tem **RootEngines** biomechanical heart nodes that reorganize corridors, threatening to erase the path behind PCs.

Trial of Worth To claim the Keystone, PCs must:

tem **Speak or fully assemble the heroine's name.** tem **Acknowledge her sacrifice and its injustice.** tem **Swear an oath to restore her saga publicly.**

Oath refusal? The Keystone remains inert or lashes out violently.

Backlash Possibilities If PCs try to take the Keystone without the oath:

tem the heroine becomes their eternal Nemesis, tem the Resonant Keystone fractures (marked with their names), tem and Act V begins with Payden's Port collapsing.

Act IV Ends When:

tem the PCs physically hold the **Resonant Keystone**, and tem their bond or enmity with the heroine is sealed.

Act V: The Last Saga The Seal and the Spear

labelact5:lastaga

Tone: mythic horror, tragic revelation, ritual triumph

The HeartFortress shudders as roots split, mist curls in reverse, and the pinned druid's body flexes against the Golden Thorn. The party stands where the curse began and will end or repeat.

section*The Awakening of the Husk

If the PCs disturbed the Thorn, or if the Name remains incomplete:

tem The **Druid of the Mist** reanimates. tem Rootbone walls shatter into a **spiral arena**. tem The husk becomes a **multiphasic boss** (see Stat Block).

The party cannot kill it only *subdue* or *pin* it again. Its flesh reforms, its bones knit; it is the curse given shape.

Final Objective: Hold long enough to force it beneath the Thorn.

section*Intervention of the Heroine Shade

If the PCs completed the Name Quest (Section ??):

tem The Heroine Shade manifests in full Valkyric radiance. tem She strides through the mist untouched, spear alight. tem Her presence weakens the husk's regeneration.

Resolution Trigger A PC must proclaim her Name aloud as the Shade strikes only then does the cycle break.

If done, the Shade impales the Druid again with:

tem golden light, tem cascading roots, tem and the sighs of a thousand dead.

The arena collapses inward, and the mist recoils violently.

section*If the Name Was Not Restored

The husk overwhelms the fortress's structure:

tem Root corridors twist and collapse. tem Mist seals passages behind the party. tem They must flee through the **RootVault escape path**.

Survival is victory but the curse remains, stronger than before. The Golden Thorn becomes inert until her Name is remembered in future play.

section*Loot, Legacy, and Consequences

If the Name Was Restored

tem PCs gain **Saga Reputation +1**. tem The Heroine becomes a **Patron of Valor, Memory, and Resurrection**. tem The Mist withdraws for a generation belllines strengthen. tem The Golden Thorn ascends in power (see Artifact Upgrades).

If the PCs Only RePinned the Druid

tem The fortress stabilises. tem The Mist is contained, not ended. tem PCs become *known* but without honor or clarity. tem The Thorn is unchanged, awaiting remembrance.

If the PCs Failed or Fled

tem Mist incursions increase for months. tem Belllines must be rebuilt at great cost. tem PCs are viewed with suspicion or blame.

section*Epilogue: The Heroine's Choice

If restored:

"My saga is yours now yours is mine. Go and let the living remember."

She dissolves into starlight but may return as:

tem a Patron, tem a guide spirit, tem or a PC boon (once/arc miracle of defense or intervention).

If not restored, her Shade remains bound:

tem sometimes an ally, tem more often a Nemesis in later arcs, tem forever seeking one who will speak her name.

GM Guidance: MultiPhasic Boss Confrontation Removing the tuningspike or attempting to destroy the husk awakens the **First Druid** in a catastrophic resurrection state. This is not a standard fight it is a ritualized horror battle with shifting phases and survival focus.

Phase I: The Husk Wakes

tem The petrified body reanimates, still impaled. tem It lashes mist tendrils and summons *rootshade guardians*. tem Attacks ignore armor unless the PCs invoke sacred names or oaths.

Objective: Break its stabilization the spike needs to be removed or driven *deeper*.

Phase II: The Unbound Druid When the spike shifts:

tem The husk splits open along its old wounds. tem The druid's true form a writhing tangle of bone, antler, and liquid mist pulls free. tem Mist thickens; PCs must navigate collapsing terrain and hallucinations.

Abilities:

tem *Corrupted Command* rerolls PC successes into failures in scenes of desecration. tem *Mist Rebirth* dismissed enemies reform unless sanctified.

Objective: Force the druid back to the sanctumheart where the spike can restrain it again.

Phase III: The Heart Rift Push the druid to the spike altar the battlefield becomes a circular pit of oaths, death echoes, and sagas written in air.

tem PCs must endure mist storms, identity erosion, and memory theft. tem The druid attempts to *rewrite one PC into its replacement host*.

Objective: Impale the druid again but only through a sacrifice, bargain, or declared deed.

Conditional Intervention: The Heroic Shade If the party has restored the heroine's name:

tem Her shade manifests behind the druid as a golden silhouette. tem She seizes the spike herself and drives it home through the druid's heartcore. tem Mist recoils; servants disintegrate; the sanctum stabilizes.

This ending:

tem restores the status quo, tem seals the husk back into slumber, tem and confirms the heroine as a protector rather than nemesis.

If Her Name Is Not Restored The fight must continue through three additional rounds of escalating horror:

tem the druid's antler mass becomes a crown of thorns, tem a PC must willingly offer an oath and blood to bind the spike, tem otherwise the fortress collapses and the Mist erupts outward.

If the fight ends without the heroine intervening, the victory is pyrrhic the druid is bound, but the Mist threshold expands, warping the wider region.

Reward for the True Name Path If her true saga is spoken before or during the battle:

tem the fight ends early in dramatic fashion, tem the heroine becomes a continuing NPC patron or ally, tem PCs may take her boon or blessing as a campaignlong tag.

This version preserves high tension while allowing the namerestoration path to feel mythic and consequential.

Act III Ends When:

tem PCs understand that true salvation lies below, tem their relationship to the heroine is set (Nemesis, Test, or Maybe Ally), tem and the path to the vault opens willingly or through collapse.

1.5 Key Threats

section*Mistwraiths (Tier IV Horrors)

Secrets made flesh. Feed on awareness and fear. Appear where the party hesitates or falters.

section*Shadewalkers (Tier III Undead)

Corpsepuppets bound in root and bone. Slow, relentless, territorial.

section*Direwood Beasts

Animals twisted by necromantic saturation. Symptoms: extra limbs, eyeless faces, echoing screams.

section*The Nameless Heroine

Shadequeen, tragic antagonist. If encountered before her name is found, treat her as a boss encounter. If her name is revealed midbattle, she collapses into grief rather than rage.

1.6 Environmental Horror

Core Tags:

tem **[MISTCHOKED]** Disorienting and oppressive. tem **[HAUNTED]** Reality shows seams; time loops. tem **[STARVEDWORLD]** No food, no warmth, whispers that sap Resolve.

Consider starvation, dehydration, and willdespair as slow pressures. The Direwood wants them to give up or accept its bargain.

1.7 Rewards and Consequences

section*CurseBreaker Outcomes

tem **SagaBearer:** PCs gain renown as keepers of a forgotten truth. tem **Artifact Wardens:** They inherit the gilden spearnow dormant unless wielded in her name. tem **Map Change:** The Mistline shifts; local politics scramble to react.

section*Failure or Refusal

tem The Mist expands or mutates. tem The heroine becomes a recurring nemesis. tem PCs are marked by the Direwood hunted by nightmares or undead emissaries.

1.8 Using With Any Setting

Plug this adventure into:

tem a Vikingflavored frontier, tem a Slavic cursed forest, tem a Romanized empire borderland, tem a gothic or Celtic wilderness, tem or a colonial frontier horror setting.

Swap religions, factions, and cultural icons as needed the core dynamics remain:

tem **Forgotten hero as antagonist** tem **Curse anchored in erasure of identity** tem
The truth is the weapon, not the sword

This keeps the module standalone, portable, and emotionally powerful.

Large **Tales of the Direwood**

A Traveler's Briefing for Those Who Walk Beyond the Bell Line

What is the Direwood?

A blighted forest where fog is older than the trees. No map draws the same twice. Beasts walk on borrowed bones. Time forgets to move correctly.

What the Elders Say:

tem Once it guarded the borderlands. tem Now it breathes death instead. tem Something within remembers us.

Safe Conduct Within the Mist

tem Travel in pairs; loneliness draws attention. tem Firelight helps, but only if you believe it will. tem Bells keep the lesser spirits away until they learn you. tem Do not chase echoes; if someone calls your name, check if their feet touch the ground.

Signs of Corruption

tem Roots that bleed when cut. tem Faces where bark should be. tem Whispers in languages you almost know.

Things Seen Near the Heartwood

tem Towers of petrified wood and bone. tem A spearhead of gold hammered through stone. tem A phantom warrior in ruined mail watching from the mist.

The Nameless Hero

tem Locals speak of the "Warden Without Name." tem Some call her guardian, others curse her as betrayer. tem Legend holds she fought a great evil and died forgotten.

Rumors and Warnings

tem *"If you speak her name, she might listen."* tem *"If you mock her, she will find you."* tem *"The spear keeps him dead but keeps her bound."*

Why Venture In?

tem To stop the creeping Mist. tem To find lost knowledge. tem To free or defeat the Warden. tem To discover her true name.

Advice from Survivors

tem Bring rope, salt, bells, and flame. tem Do not trust your memories inside. tem When in doubtspeak truth, not courage.

*The Direwood does not hate you.
It simply remembers before you do.*

sectionRites of the Druid of the Mist labelrites:mistrdruid dexRites!Druid of the Mist

These rites reflect the patron's ethos: *erode, unmake, devour, dissolve.*

Followers learn that every invocation is a transaction power traded for identity.

Low Rites (46 XP)

tem[Mist's Caress] *Scene; Zone; No.*

[VEIL] [SENSE] [DRAIN]

Call thin fog across Near. Gain +1 die to detect fear, fatigue, or spiritual imbalance. Living foes suffer unease; undead gain interest. tem[Whisper of Hollow Roots] *Scene; Self; No.*

[SENSE] [GUIDE]

Hear paths where boundaries blur. Once per scene, bypass mundane impediment (wall, guard, protocol) narratively; GM provides complication. tem[Sap of Forgetting] *Scene; Touch; Yes.*

[DRAIN] [WEAKEN]

Inflict 1 die to resistance rolls for one exchange as the target's name wavers. Push It: Target forgets one small truth or detail temporarily. tem[Bitter Blossom Mark] *Extended; Close; Yes.*

[CURSE] [DECAY]

Plant a sigil that corrupts soil, masonry, or a social oath. Start a **Creeping Ruin [4]** timer; when full, something breaks.

Standard Rites (79 XP)

tem[Root of Unmaking] *Scene; Zone; Yes.*

[DECAY] [BIND] [CORRUPT]

Infect a structure, body, or agreement with invisible rot. Allies gain +1 die to exploit fractures; orderbased actions suffer +1 DV. tem[Shroud of Dissolution] *Scene; Self; Yes.*

[VEIL] [CONCEAL]

Become indistinct: sound muffles, form blurs. Gain +1 die on evasion/stealth; fail with 1s risks namefragment loss (GM chooses). tem[Bone Orchard Bloom] *Scene; Zone; Yes.*

[ANIMATE] [AREA] [CORRUPT]

Corpses or dead roots animate as spectral vines/limbs that hinder foes. Create **Difficult Terrain** and start a **Gravegarden [4]** timer. tem[Harvester's Breath] *Scene; Zone; Yes.*

[DRAIN] [FEED] [AREA]

Draw fatigue, sorrow, or fear from all in Near. Convert one such condition into +1 die for yourself or a chosen ally.

High Rites (1014 XP)

tem[Reclaim the Boundary] *Scene; Zone; Yes.*

[DOMAIN] [CURSE] [REWRITE]

Select a place or law; for the scene, its borders cease functioning. Walls don't divide, ranks

don't compel, names are unreliable. Resistance causes sensory fragmentation (Position 1 next exchange). tem[Pale Menagerie] *Scene; Near; Yes*.

[SUMMON] [UNDEAD] [COMMAND]

Call forth 13 mistechoes (Cap 2) that obey simple urges. They dissolve when named or sanctified. tem[Walk of Unbeing] *Scene; Self; Yes*.

[PHASE] [VEIL] [MOVE]

Step through boundaries, walls, or social constraints. Treat any Blocked route as Open but mark **1 Name Erosion**. tem[Famine of the Living Word] *Scene; Far; Yes*.

[CURSE] [SILENCE] [BLIGHT]

Silence a leader, liturgy, or institution. For one scene, oaths, commands, or blessings falter. GM marks **Narrative Ruin** consequences linger.

Apex Rite (1520 XP)

tem[The Mist Devours the Story] *Extended; Domain; Yes*.

[UNMAKE] [DOMAIN] [APOCALYPSE]

Declare a rooted structure a keep, dynasty, covenant, religion, or name. Begin **The Unmaking [6+]** timer. When full, that thing loses identity: histories rewrite, memories fracture, its powerbase dissolves. Survivors may cling to fragments, but it never becomes the same again. *Cost:* Mark **3 Erosion**, lose one personal truth, risk becoming an avatar.

section*Corruption Erosion Mechanics dexCorruption dexIdentity Loss

Followers of the Mist do not track *Obligation*; they track **Erosion**.

Each time a rite produces backlash or a 1 is rolled:

tem erase a memory, tem distort a feature, tem or lose a social bond.

At **3+ Erosion**, the GM may enforce:

tem shadowspeech, tem hostile mist manifestations, tem or NPCs forgetting the PC's name.

At **6+ Erosion**, the patron attempts apotheosis the character becomes a *MistThing* unless named and anchored by others.

sectionSpellwheel: The Druid of the Mist ↳spellwheel:mistrdruid

line Sigil	Aspect	Tags	Invocation Theme
line Root	Boundary	[BIND][DECAY]	Unmake structure, rot identity, bind paths or truths
line Bloom	Hunger	[DRAIN][FEED]	Harvest fear/fatigue; convert suffering into momentum
line Mist	Veil	[VEIL][SENSE]	Cloud meaning; detect cracks, sorrow, forgotten names
line Bone	Unlife	[ANIMATE][CORRUPT]	Raise echoes; twist flesh or soil with old death
line Hollow	Dominion	[CURSE][REWRITE]	bend will, rewrite laws, fracture names and memories
line Rift	Tide of Unbeing	[PHASE][UNMAKE]	erase borders, dissolve authority, or step through reality
line			

Usage Notes Cantors assemble invocations by chaining:

$$\textit{Aspect} + \textit{Tags} + \textit{Channel}$$

Invokerstyle play treats the wheel as a *menu*:

tem Choose 12 Aspects tem Add 13 matching Tags tem State the narrative form (fog, vines, sorrow, whispers)

The more the invocation erodes boundaries or identity, the higher the DV and the greater the Erosion risk.

1.9 Patron: The Heroine of the Mist

labelpatron:misteroine dexPatrons!Heroine of the Mist

Aspect *Memory, Oath, Bloodshed in Defense*

Once mortal now halfValkyrie, halfMournWarden. She embodies:

tem valor without recognition, tem sacrifice without audience, tem and the terrible cost of defending those who never remember you.

Sphere of Influence

tem names, tem sagas, tem identity persistence, tem righteous vengeance, tem guardianship of the innocent, tem oaths that bind but uplift.

Devotional Archetypes

tem[OathKeepers:] sworn blades, bodyguards, shieldbearers tem[SagaWardens:] skalds, lore-keepers, the memoryobsessed tem[The Forgotten:] outcasts, orphans, traumatised veterans

Taboos

tem abandoning a sworn charge, tem erasing someone's rightful name, tem cowardice in duty.

sectionMiracles and Major Rites Devotional power flows through remembrance and sacrifice.

Rites (General Access)

tem[Namebinding:] Mark 1 Fatigue grant an ally +1 **Position** for defending or reclaiming identity. tem[Saga's Spark:] Once per scene, declare a past victory to gain +1 **die** for an action must narrate the remembered deed. tem[Shield of the Forgotten:] Allies under your protection count as **one tier higher** for resisting fear or domination. tem[Blood Oath:] Swear protection over a person or truth; gain a boon whenever fulfilling that oath through hardship. tem[Witness to Glory:] Convert suffering (Fatigue/Harm) into +1 SB when defending others.

sectionHigher Mysteries (Prestige/Epic Rites)

tem[Reclaim the Name:] Restore a forgotten truth or identity; remove Mist penalties for the scene. tem[MistSplitting Spear:] Manifest spectral spear; +2 dice vs undead and corrupted oathbreakers. tem[Saga Ascent:] Once per session, prevent death of one ally they rise with 1 Harm and a memory of you they cannot shake. tem[The Last Watch:] Bind your spirit to a place or charge; if abandoned, you become a shade that hunts oathbreakers.

sectionSpellwheel: The Heroine of the Mist labelspellwheel:misteroine

line Sigil	Aspect	Tags	Invocation Theme
line Spear	Valor	[SMITE][PURIFY]	punish undead, strike corruption, reveal truth
line Shield	Oath	[GUARD][ENDURE]	intercept harm, stand immovable, sanctify ground
line Torch	Memory	[REVEAL][NAME]	expose hidden identity; illuminate forgotten stories
line Tears	Sacrifice	[BIND][HEAL]	heal through cost; bind wounds, take suffering
line Crown	Remembrance	[SAGA][INSPIRE]	uplift allies, declare deeds into reality, rewrite legacy
line Bell	Requiem	[BANISH][SEAL]	end hauntings; sever curses; close breaches
line			

Cantor/Invoker Themes

tem songs of valor, tem whispered sagas, tem spearlight metaphors, tem radiant mist, tem oathfire halos.

sectionDevotional Gifts (Mechanical Boons)

tem **Once per session:** treat any Desperate defense as Dominant. tem When defending others, gain +1d to resist fear, torment, or loss. tem When fulfilling sworn duty under hardship, **mark 1 SB.**

sectionNarrative Role in the Direwood Adventure If her true Name is restored:

tem she manifests at Act V, tem impales the Druid with the *Golden Thorn*, tem and offers one PC her blessing or burden.

If her Name remains lost:

tem she remains a Nemesis Shade, tem hunting oathbreakers and defilers, tem until someone speaks her back into the world.

1.10 Nemesis Profile: The Heroine Shade

labelnemesis:misteroine dexNemesis!Heroine of the Mist

Role *Guardian of memory, judge of oaths, hunter of the unworthy.*

A spectral shieldmaiden formed of mist and radiant sorrow. She is tragedy weaponised.

Tier IV (Legendary Adversary)

Concept Tags [VALKYRIE] [OATH] [MOURN] [JUDGE] [SAGA]

section*Core Traits

tem[Spirit:] 6 tem[Resolve:] 5 tem[Body:] 4 tem[Speed:] 3 tem[Presence:] 6

Harm Capacity: 6 (Cannot be killed until her Name is restored)

Armor: 2 (Spectral Plate)

section*Phase Structure

Phase I: Silent Hunt *She watches, tests, strikes symbols not flesh.*

tem Attacks inflict Conditions rather than Harm:
REVERENCE

, [FEAR], [UNWORTHY] tem If PCs perform **oathkeeping**, she withdraws for 1 exchange.

Phase II: The Shieldmaiden Revealed *Triggered when she is struck for 3+ Harm in one scene.*

tem Gains +2 dice to melee attacks. tem Her spear manifests: Harm 2, ignores Armor. tem She utters fragments of her lost Name.

Phase III: The Ascendant Shade *Triggered when PCs hold three Name Fragments or swear an oath to restore her saga.*

tem She switches from Nemesis to Trial. tem PCs may **roll to remember** (Lore + Presence).
tem If spoken true, she kneels and joins Act V.

section*Abilities

MistSplitting Spear +2 dice vs corrupted or undead foes; on 6s, pins enemy spirits.

Witness of Deeds Once per scene, invert Position against oathbreakers.

Saga Binding When PCs narrate past deeds tied to sacrifice, grant +1d to them.

Oathscour When someone abandons a charge, immediately strike Harm 2 ignoring Armor.

section*Weaknesses

tem Cannot be harmed until her Name is known. tem Will not strike the innocent unless manipulated. tem Spear shattered by betrayal or false remembrance.

1.11 Artifact: The Golden Thorn

labelartifact:goldenhorn dexArtifacts!Golden Thorn

Origin Forged by an unknown power to pierce immortal spirits and bind mistborn corruption.

Appearance A meterlong gilded pin, rootetched, warm to the touch, humming faintly with invoked names.

Properties

tem **Harm 2**; ignores Armor on undead or cursed entities. tem When used to impale, creates a **Banishment Seal**. tem If wielded by one who knows the Heroine's true Name, treat as **Harm 3**.

section*Golden Thorn Invocation Rites These may be used by Cantors, Invokers, or Runekeepers.

Thorn Seal [BANISH] [SEAL] [MIST] impale a spirit, pinning it to reality.

Memory Piercing [NAME] [REVEAL] the impaled target utters a name or truth unwillingly.

Vigilant Thorn [GUARD] [WARD] mark a threshold; undead must test to cross.

Radiant Impalement [PURIFY] [LIGHT] [SPEAR] destroy spectral extensions or illusions.

Restriction: May only be used at full potency by one who has sworn an oath to restore the forgotten.

Running Direwood: GM Tips and Appendix

A Preparation Checklist

A.1 Session Zero Considerations

tem Confirm player comfort with horror themes (psychological horror, identity loss, existential dread) tem Establish safety tools (XCard, Script Change) for intense scenes tem Review character backgrounds for integration hooks tem Set expectations for investigative vs. combat focus

A.2 PreSession Preparation

tem Map key faction NPCs with clear motivations tem Prepare 34 name fragment discovery scenarios tem Review Patron mechanics for The Heroine and The Druid tem Set up tracking sheets for:tem Dread Timer tem Memory Track tem Faction attitudes tem Environmental consequences

tem Prepare key location descriptions (Payden's Port, Direwood sectors, Fortress Heart)

B Pacing and Flow Management

B.1 Act I: Payden's Port

tem **Focus:** Political tension + creeping horror tem **Key Scenes:** Faction meetings, first breach, departure tem **Pacing:** 23 sessions tem **GM Tips:**tem Use omens liberally

(dead gulls, fog children) tem Let factions compete for PC attention tem Don't rush the departure build dread

B.2 Act II: Through the Direwood

tem **Focus:** Survival horror + mythic revelation tem **Key Mechanics:** Environmental table, name fragments, Heroine's phantom tem **Pacing:** 34 sessions tem **GM Tips:**tem Vary the environmental effects don't use them every scene tem Let the Heroine's phantom shift based on PC actions tem Name fragments should feel earned, not random

B.3 Act III: The Fortress Heart

tem **Focus:** Grim revelation + predatory architecture tem **Key Mechanics:** Room generator, adversary table, Heroine's judgment tem **Pacing:** 23 sessions tem **GM Tips:**tem The fortress should feel alive and reactive tem Use the Heroine as a dynamic antagonist, not static boss tem Let the PCs' Memory Track influence her behavior

C Key Mechanical Reminders

C.1 Story Beat Economy

øring

line SB	Direwood Use	Impact
line 1 SB	Minor environmental shift	Path loops, fog thickens
2 SB	Moderate complication	Wraith attraction, memory loss
3 SB	Serious threat	Shadewalker patrol, trap activation
4+ SB	Major escalation	Heroine's wrath, fortress restructuring
line		

tionDirewood Story Beat Applications

C.2 Environmental Horror Tags

tem **[MISTCHOKED]:** Disorientation, impaired perception, fear generation tem **[HAUNTED]:** Reality seams, time loops, memory distortion tem **[STARVEDWORLD]:** Resource scarcity, willdraining, identity erosion

D Character Archetype Support

D.1 Tank/Controller Players

tem Emphasize defensive positioning opportunities tem Provide clear crowd control scenarios tem Reward proactive threat management

D.2 Striker/DPS Players

tem Offer tactical advantage positioning tem Include mobile combat scenarios tem Provide clear damagedealing opportunities

D.3 Support/Buffer Players

tem Create partycohesion challenges tem Include social manipulation opportunities tem Provide healing/resource management moments

D.4 Utility/Scout Players

tem Design puzzle/problemsolving scenarios tem Include explorationfocused challenges tem Reward specialized skill usage

E Thematic Reinforcement

E.1 Consistency Tips

tem Always tie mechanical effects to narrative causes tem Let the forest react to player choices thematically tem Use recurring motifs (bones, mist, names, memory) tem Maintain the tension between heroism and tragedy

E.2 Horror Pacing

tem **Establish Normalcy**: Start with recognizable elements tem **Introduce Wrongness**: Small, subtle violations tem **Escalate Gradually**: Build to major violations tem **Provide Relief**: Moments of safety or clarity tem **Return Stronger**: Escalate beyond initial wrongness

F Troubleshooting Common Issues

F.1 Players Moving Too Slowly

tem Increase environmental pressure (Dread Timer ticks) tem Introduce timesensitive threats tem Use faction pressure from Payden's Port

F.2 Players Rushing Ahead

tem Enforce consequences for missed investigation tem Use environmental barriers that require preparation tem Let important clues become inaccessible

F.3 Combat Dominance

tem Emphasize noncombat solutions to threats tem Use adversaries that are difficult to defeat conventionally tem Introduce social or psychological consequences

F.4 Investigation Stalling

tem Provide multiple paths to information tem Use active investigation (visions, dreams, encounters) tem Let the environment provide clues organically

G Optional Variations

G.1 Shortened Campaign

tem Focus on core mystery (name restoration) tem Reduce faction complexity tem Streamline environmental challenges tem Condense fortress exploration

G.2 Increased Horror Focus

tem Emphasize psychological effects tem Increase memory distortion elements tem Add more personal horror connections tem Reduce combat options

G.3 Mythic Heroism Focus

tem Emphasize the Heroine's redemption arc tem Provide more opportunities for legendary actions tem Focus on saga and legacy themes tem Reduce horror elements

H Tracking Sheets and Handouts

H.1 Player Tracking

tem Memory Track shared sheet tem Name Fragment collection log tem Faction relationship tracker tem Direwood survival log

H.2 GM Tracking

tem Dread Timer status tem Heroine's attitude tracker tem Environmental effect log tem Faction pressure indicators

I Conclusion

Remember: The Direwood responds to the players' approach. Respect their choices, escalate meaningfully, and let the tragedy of the forgotten heroine drive both horror and hope.

Thematic Tier III Character Examples

J Aeler Military Engineer

Name: Thrain Stonecaller

Background: Aeler Charter Apprentice

Concept: FortressCraft Master who specializes in defensive engineering and siegebreaking

Attributes: Body 3, Wits 4, Spirit 3, Presence 2

Skills: Craft 4, Tinker 3, Tactics 3, Lore 2

Talents: Vent Prior's Training (3 XP), StoneSense (5 XP), Defensive Architecture (4 XP)

Patron: The Sealed Gate

Familiar: Thiasos Ironscale (Stone Sentinel)

Codex: Charter of the Deep Vaults

Assets:

tem Minor: Engineering Kit (surveyor's tools, measuring chains) tem Follower: Gunnvor Ironwright (Cap 2 Siege Specialist)

Background Tags: CharterStamped, StoneSpeech Initiate

Signature Contact: Master Builder Emrik (Cap 1)

Background Boon: Once/session around structures, ignore the first environmental complication from collapse or strain.

K Mistland Local Guide

Name: Uria Mistweaver

Background: Mistlands BellKeeper

Concept: Belltender turned wilderness guide who knows the dangerous paths through the fog

Attributes: Body 2, Wits 3, Spirit 4, Presence 3

Skills: Survival 4, Perception 3, Lore 3, Sway 2

Talents: Heightened Senses (3 XP), Mist Reading (4 XP), BellSpeech (3 XP)

Patron: The Silent Choir

Familiar: Whisper (Corvid Scout)

Codex: Songs of the Dusk Bells

Assets:

tem Minor: BellPouch (ceremonial handbells) tem Follower: Bramble Thornwick (Cap 3 Wilderness Guide)

Background Tags: BellLaw, Causeway Rights

Signature Contact: DuskWarden Morn (Cap 1)

Background Boon: Once/session in mist, choose routeorsafety: negate a travel delay or downgrade a hazard.

L Zakov Smuggler Captain

Name: Captain "Shadow" Kestra Voss

Background: Underworld Hand

Concept: Pirateturnedsmuggler who runs contraband past Aeler checkpoints

Attributes: Body 3, Wits 4, Spirit 3, Presence 3

Skills: Sway 4, Ranged 3, Subterfuge 3, Survival 2

Talents: Second Wind (2 XP), Keen Senses (2 XP), Social Chameleon (4 XP), Shipmaster's Instinct (4 XP)

Patron: Raéyn (Mistress of the Sea)

Familiar: Stormrider (Seabird Scout)

Codex: TideRider's Charter

Assets:

tem Minor: Hidden Cargo Compartment tem Standard: Smuggling Vessel "Night's Passage"
tem Follower: Finn the Knife (Cap 3 Deckhand/Scout)

Background Tags: Harbor Handsigns, Black Banner Cant

Signature Contact: Fence Master Torr (Cap 1)

Background Boon: Once/session when using a cant, gain +1d to set up or slip out.

M Linnic TraderRaider

Name: Bjorn Iceheart

Background: Frontier Marcher Homesteader

Concept: Seafaring trader who raids when trade winds fail

Attributes: Body 4, Wits 3, Spirit 3, Presence 3

Skills: Melee 4, Ranged 3, Survival 3, Command 2

Talents: Berserker Rage (8 XP), Weapon Mastery (4 XP), Cold Weather Survival (3 XP), Naval Tactics (4 XP)

Patron: Thrysos (King of Revels)

Familiar: Frostfang (Wolf Companion)

Codex: Saga of the WhaleRoad

Assets:

tem Minor: Dragon Boat "Stormbreaker" tem Standard: Trading Post in Linnstad tem
Follower: Sigrun Ironscale (Cap 3 WarriorTrader)

Background Tags: VeteranoftheMarches, Muster Papers

Signature Contact: ClanChief Harald (Cap 1)

Background Boon: Once/session in organized violence, ignore the first point of situational Disadvantage from confusion or fear.

N Lethaial Valewood Ranger

Name: Aelindra Greenwalker

Background: Rural Valewood Forager

Concept: Forest guardian who protects ancient paths from outsiders

Attributes: Body 3, Wits 4, Spirit 3, Presence 2

Skills: Nature 4, Stealth 3, Perception 3, Lore 3

Talents: Canopy Spring (4 XP), Scent of Rain (4 XP), Green Speech (3 XP), ArrowSong (4 XP)

Patron: Grimmir (Wild Speaker)

Familiar: Thornwhisper (Forest Cat)

Codex: Songs of Root and Branch

Assets:

tem Minor: Hunter's Bow "Whisperleaf" tem Follower: Moss (Cap 2 Forest Guide/Healer)

Background Tags: Green Courts Token, RiverFerry Nod

Signature Contact: LeafWarden Sylvan (Cap 1)

Background Boon: Once/session in the wild, downgrade a Travel complication by one step.

O Aelinnel Gnome Artificer

Name: Quillwick Coppermeasure

Background: Academic of the Dialogues

Concept: Meticulous inventor who creates magical devices using precise calculations

Attributes: Body 2, Wits 5, Spirit 2, Presence 3

Skills: Craft 4, Arcana 3, Investigation 3, Lore 3

Talents: Long Memory (3 XP), Number Music (4 XP), Clockwork Mastery (6 XP), TwoLedger

Talk (3 XP)

Patron: Sacred Geometry

Familiar: Cogwheel (Mechanical Companion)

Codex: Theorems of Perfect Proportion

Assets:

tem Minor: Workshop with Precision Tools tem Standard: Calculating Engine (Minor Artifact)

tem Follower: Tink (Cap 2 Apprentice/Assistant)

Background Tags: SchoolSealed, Reading Privileges

Signature Contact: Lecturer Brightmind (Cap 1)

Background Boon: Once/session in research or disputation, ask one clarifying question the GM must answer plainly.

P Aelaerem Halfling Herbalist

Name: Bramble Goodwort

Background: Rural Valewood Forager

Concept: Gentle healer who knows the dangerous plants of borderlands

Attributes: Body 2, Wits 3, Spirit 4, Presence 3

Skills: Medicine 4, Nature 3, Perception 3, Sway 2

Talents: Heightened Senses (3 XP), RootBalance (3 XP), Healing Touch (4 XP), Herb Lore (3 XP)

Patron: The Silent Choir

Familiar: Sage (Garden Snake)

Codex: Remedies of the Hearth

Assets:

tem Minor: Herb Garden and Apothecary Kit tem Follower: Pip Willowfoot (Cap 2 Gatherer/Apprentice)

Background Tags: Neighborhood Trust, GuildFriend

Signature Contact: Village Elder Rose (Cap 1)

Background Boon: Once/session among familiar folk, convert a failure on routine labor to a successwithcost.